CHAPTER 33

RUBY

Medha Laud, who is at the ECB and has looked after me most of my playing career, takes my requests. Everyone within the camp is understanding and tells me that I absolutely should go. I can feel how much there's resting on this Ashes, because Medha upgrades my flight to first class. It's the first time I've ever experienced it. I get on the flight thinking, *Wow, everyone really wants to win this Ashes away from home, don't they?* My sleep is something being monitored as closely as Lola's back home.

As soon as I'm sitting down on the plane though, any idea of a luxury flight suddenly leaves me. I've got to get back in time. I can't miss the birth. If I could upgrade again, swap with the pilot, put the foot down on the accelerator, I would. I spend remainder of the journey trying to work out a way to ask him if he can go faster, and maybe he would if I explained the situation calmly but insistently. The panic intensifies the closer I get to home – the world shifting from an Ashes tour of unprecedented hope and intensity, morphing back into something else at home, a perspective new and exciting. When I walk through the door, Daniella is there. We don't even get a chance to look at each other. Her face freezes.

'What?' I ask.

'My waters have broken,' she says.

It literally happens the moment I walk through the door, like the whole thing is some kind of predestined sequence of events and working to the absolute millisecond to ensure it all falls together. We need to go to the hospital now.

I am up all night, reading, trying to stay on Australian time, as Daniella tries to get some sleep. I must have fallen asleep at some point because I come to only to be woken by Daniella again in agony while she's in labour.